

SANTA *
BARBARA *

AND AROUND THERE



* EDWARDS ROBERTS *





THE SANTA BARBARA BAY.

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BY

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CHAPTER II.

ALONG THE PACIFIC SHORE.

THE Santa Barbara valley has an average width of from two to four miles, and is forty-five miles long. It extends from Gaviota Pass, a narrow passage across the Santa Ynez range, to Rincon Hill, and is divided into three distinct districts. That of Carpenteria lies between Rincon and Ortega Hill, and next to it is El Montecito, which borders the bay and stretches back to the foothills. The third division, the longest of all, is the Santa Barbara valley proper. In it are the town, the village of Goleta, and the

large fruit and nut ranches nestled at the base of the range.

The Bay of Santa Barbara is little more than an open roadstead, or channel. It is twenty miles wide, and is protected from the open sea by four long, mountainous islands. From a point less than a mile west of the wharf the shore extends in an almost unbroken succession of crescent beaches as far as Rincon, twenty miles away. To ride or drive along this hard, shining roadway, is at all seasons of the year a popular pastime. At low tide one may ride its entire length. In places the beach is bordered by open fields, and again is lined by high yellow cliffs, with grass-grown tops.

On sunlit days, which are the rule rather than the exception at Santa Barbara, the colorings seen on this ride are varied and beautiful. Then the cliffs are of deepest yellow, the bay is blue, and the distant islands are purpled.

is rarely a day when Chinese fishing smacks are not to be seen sailing about the bay ; and those who do not fear the waves often cross to the islands, where they make camp, and enjoy life for a week or more on those isolated worlds which, years ago, were the home of now forgotten Indians.

The islands are named Santa Rosa, Santa Cruz, San Miguel and Ana Capa. They are private property, and are used for sheep-ranges. The ground contains many curious Indian implements, and on San Miguel the Spanish explorer Cabrillo was buried. The islands are of various shape and size, one being more than twenty miles long and covered with hills that have an elevation of two thousand feet above sea level. All are the home of myriads of birds, and along their beaches are vast quantities of abalone shells, which are gathered, shipped to France, and made into buttons.

On the smallest island was enacted the tragedy of the "Lost Woman of San Nicholas," which at Santa Barbara is a familiar tale. The story begins with the removal of a number of Indians from San Nicholas, in 1836. Just as they were embarking, one of the women discovered that her child had been left behind. Returning for it, she was abandoned by her companions, who were obliged by a coming storm to set sail for the mainland. It was intended to return so soon as the weather permitted, but years passed away, and the woman in time was forgotten and left to her fate.

Twenty years later, a hunter named George Nidever, of Santa Barbara, visited the island for otters. While there, he determined to look for the woman. After careful search he found three huts made of whale-ribs and brush, and from where they stood extended an open plain,

in the centre of which Nidever saw the object of his journey. The woman's dress was made of skins and feathers, and her hair hung in tangled masses from her bare head. When discovered, she was cutting blubber from a seal which she had killed, but on seeing her visitor she received him with every manifestation of delight, and readily accompanied him to his boat. Signs were made her to enter it, and on her doing so, Nidever sailed across the bay, and brought his charge to Santa Barbara.

Her arrival there created great excitement, and hundreds called at Nidever's house to see her. Although she could not have been more than fifty years old, she was gray-haired and emaciated. Her expression was one of blank ignorance, and her skin was dry and wrinkled. Her language, strange as it may seem, considering the comparatively short time she had

been lost, was unintelligible to all. Those who considered themselves masters of every Indián tongue, could not understand a word that she said. Owing to this fact, the story of her hermitage was never known. What became of the child she returned from the boat to find on that fatal day in 1836, is a matter of pure conjecture. How long it lived and where it was buried were facts that could not be discovered. The woman appeared to have lost all human instincts, and to every question asked made no answer that could be understood. In three months after her rescue she died, and was buried by the Mission Fathers.

George Nidever, the hero of the rescue, was a well-known character. His widow still lives at Santa Barbara, and the stories of her husband's good qualities and bravery are innumerable. In all accounts he is pictured as a second Leatherstocking, — brave and honest,

and familiar with Nature and Indians, the sea and its islands. In an essay on "Courage," Ralph Waldo Emerson quotes a ballad regarding pure courage, of which Nidever is the subject.

